The ferocious energy that Akbar displayed during his battles and campaigns, in peacetime was channelled into the meticulous and careful attention he gave to all that was happening around him. ‘He is much loved as well as feared by his people,’ wrote Henriques, the Jesuit, ‘and is very hardworking; to the end he is never idle, he knows a little of all trades and sometimes loves to practise them before his people either as a carpenter or as a blacksmith or as an armourer, filing and even quite often bleeding some of his captains in public as he once expertly bled a captain, who needed it, before us and his people.’ Endearingly, Akbar could sometimes be distracted and enthralled by the most insubstantial things, causing Abu’l Fazl much torment as he imagined a grander purpose for everything Akbar was involved in. ‘His majesty from curiosity likes to see spider fights,’ admitted Abu’l Fazl, this time quite undone by the Padshah, ‘and amuses himself in watching the attempts of the flies to escape, their jumps, and combats with their foe’. The Jesuits, too, described a Padshah who was distracted from time to time.

> At one time he would be deeply immersed in state affairs or giving audiences to his subjects, and the next moment he would be seen shearing camels, hewing stones, cutting wood, or hammering iron, and doing all with as much diligence as though engaged in his own particular vocation.

However, in 1582, there was a project which was entirely worthy of Abu’l Fazl’s most extravagant praise, for in the maktab khana of Fatehpur Sikri, a collection of writers and theologians were starting on one of the most audacious projects of Akbar’s reign— the translation of the Mahabharat from Sanskrit to Persian. Writing about this project, Faizi said:

> With a hundred charms I am bringing an
> Ancient book
> From Hindi into Persian, the language of the court
> I stroll to see with friends
> The idol temple of Hindustan

His brother, Abu’l Fazl, was less whimsical in his assessment. He said that Akbar ‘decided to explore the reason for the hostility that divided the Muslims, Jews and Hindus and in doing so realized that their denial of one another was all too obvious’. Once Akbar had understood this problem, ‘he